REFERENCES

Dana-Farber Cancer Institute. (2026, March 19). Capecitabine (Xeloda).



Oral Cancer Medication series

Capecitabine









Dana-Farber Cancer Institute

ABOUT THIS BOOKLET

This booklet is for patients who take capecitabine for their cancer.

It will help you understand:

- What capecitabine is and how it works
- How to take your capecitabine each day
- Side effects and how to manage them
- When to call your doctor or nurse
- How to plan your family safely while on capecitabine

Read this booklet with your family. Ask your nurse or doctor if you have questions.

Updated August 2026

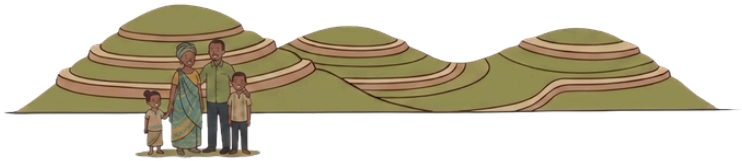
This work is licensed under a Creative Commons Attribution-NonCommercial-NoDerivatives 4.0 International License.



NOTES



FAMILY PLANNING, PREGNANCY, & BREASTFEEDING



It is very important that you do not become pregnant or get someone pregnant while taking capecitabine.

Use two methods of contraception (example: condoms AND IUD) during your treatment. Women should continue using contraception for 6 months after the end of treatment, and men should continue using contraception for 3 months after the end of treatment to prevent pregnancy.

Talk with your healthcare team about what contraceptive methods are best for you. If you are being treated for breast cancer with capecitabine, you may need to use contraceptive methods without hormones, like a copper IUD.

You should not breastfeed while taking capecitabine and for one week after stopping your medication.

TABLE OF CONTENTS

1 ABOUT THIS BOOKLET

2 TABLE OF CONTENTS

3 WHAT CAPECITABINE IS

4 HOW TO TAKE CAPECITABINE

5 CAPECITABINE SIDE EFFECTS

9 WHEN TO NOTIFY YOUR MEDICAL TEAM

10 FAMILY PLANNING, PREGNANCY, & BREASTFEEDING

IMPORTANT PHONE NUMBERS

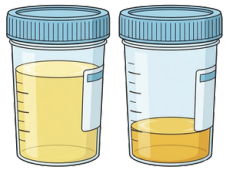
WHAT CAPECITABINE IS

Capecitabine is a type of chemotherapy, a medication that destroys cancer cells. This medicine is used to treat different types of cancer, including breast cancer, colorectal cancer, and gastric cancer.

Safe storage/safe handling of medication

- Store this medication at room temperature in a safe place away from children and food preparation areas.
- If you have unused pills, return them to the prescribing doctor at your next visit rather than discarding them at home. The plastic bag your pills come in can be thrown in the trash.
- Small amounts of chemo will be in your body waste (urine, stool, vomit) while you take capecitabine. Be careful to prevent your body waste from coming into contact with your family.
- This medicine has been prescribed only for you, do not pass it on to others. It may harm them, even if their signs of illness are the same as yours.

Signs of kidney problems:



decreased amount of urine



swelling in your ankles



blood in your urine



increased thirst

Severe skin reaction:



painful peeling



blistering



rashes

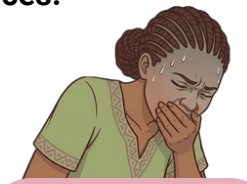
Signs of dehydration and electrolyte imbalances:



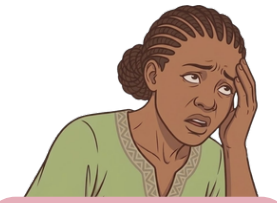
you cannot drink 8-10 cups of fluid within 24 hours



more than 7 stools in one day



uncontrolled vomiting even after taking anti-nausea medication



dizziness or fainting



stomach pain



black or bloody stool

WHEN TO NOTIFY YOUR MEDICAL TEAM

Rare, but more serious side effects are also possible. If you have any of the following signs, call your cancer doctor right away. The number to call is:

_____

Signs of infection:



fever of 38°C or higher



chills (feeling cold)

Signs of heart problems:



shortness of breath



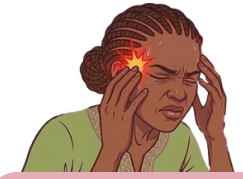
chest pain



racing heart rate



vision changes



severe headache



major weakness

Signs of liver problems:



yellow skin or eyes



dark urine

HOW TO TAKE CAPECITABINE

Take capecitabine tablets exactly as prescribed as close to 12 hours apart as possible:

- Morning: ____ 150mg tablets, _____ 500mg tablets
- Evening: ____ 150mg tablets, _____ 500mg tablets

Swallow the pills whole with a large non-alcoholic drink (~250mls) 30 minutes after eating a meal.

Wash your hands before and after taking the pills. If someone else is giving you the pills, they should be careful not to touch the pills with their hands. Pregnant and breastfeeding people should not handle your medication.

If you miss a dose of capecitabine, take it as soon as possible that day. If it is almost time for your next dose, skip the missed dose and take the scheduled dose. Do not double the amount of medication dose.
If you vomit (throw up) within 30 minutes of taking the medicine, you may repeat the dose.



CAPECITABINE SIDE EFFECTS

Hand-foot Syndrome



Hand-foot syndrome includes redness, discomfort, swelling, tingling, peeling skin, blisters, and/or bleeding in the palms or the hands or soles of the feet. To prevent and manage hand-foot syndrome:

- Avoid tight fitting shoes
- Use Vaseline on hands and feet
- The doctor may prescribe pain medication or topical steroids if severe

Diarrhea



Diarrhea may occur. To manage diarrhea:

- Drink at least 8-10 cups of fluid every day that you take capecitabine and at least 2 days afterwards
- Do not drink caffeinated drinks (like coffee), alcohol, or high-sugar drinks (like fruit juice and Fanta)
- Take the anti-diarrheal medication (loperamide) that your healthcare team gave to you if you experience diarrhea
- Take an initial dose of 4mg, then 2mg after each loose stool (maximum 16mg a day)



Hair Thinning or Hair Loss

Hair thinning or hair loss may occur. If you experience hair loss, your hair should start to grow back three to four weeks after you finish taking your medications.

- Protect your hair and scalp as much as possible, cover your head with a soft hat or scarf when outdoors

Fatigue

Fatigue may occur. The amount of fatigue can change over time while taking this medication. To manage fatigue:

- Rest and take more frequent naps
- Stay as active as you can





Infertility

Capecitabine may affect your ability to have children. Talk to your doctor for more information.

Nausea and Vomiting



Nausea and vomiting and loss of appetite may occur. To manage nausea and vomiting:

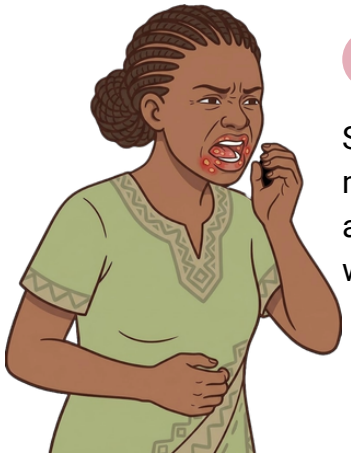
- Eat small, frequent meals throughout the day instead of larger ones
- Drink plenty of fluids as described above
- Try adding ginger to your tea or to your cooking
- Eat higher calorie foods such as beans
- Take the anti-nausea medication your healthcare team gave to you



Skin Dryness

Skin dryness may occur. To manage this symptom:

- Avoid harsh or scented soaps
- Take only one bath or shower per day. Only shower or bathe for 10 minutes or less and use lukewarm water instead of hot water.
- Dry your skin gently by patting dry with a soft towel. Do not scrub your skin. Apply lotion to keep your skin hydrated.



Mouth Sores or Mucositis

Sores, redness, burning inside your mouth or lips may occur 7-10 days after starting capecitabine. To help with mouth sores:

- Keep your mouth clean to prevent infection.
- Use a soft-bristle toothbrush for brushing your teeth.
- Mix 1 tsp salt with a large cup of water. Swish and spit 4-5 times a day.



Low Blood Cell Counts

Low blood cell counts (red blood cells, white blood cells, platelets) may occur. Lowered blood counts may cause low energy and increase your risk of infection and bleeding. To manage this side effect:

- Be careful to prevent infection (perform good hand washing, avoid people who are sick)
- Be careful to prevent bleeding (avoid activities that may cause injury)